



GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

City Critters

A cozy multiplayer life sim where the whole city is your neighborhood.

ENGINE

Godot 4

PLATFORM

PC / Steam

GENRE

3D Casual Multiplayer

RATING

E for Everyone



Contents

- 01 Project Overview
- 02 Core Gameplay Loop
- 03 Player Characters & Customization
- 04 Activities & Hobbies
- 05 The Economy & Jobs
- 06 Player Housing & Real Estate
- 07 The World: The City
- 08 NPCs & Social Systems
- 09 Technical Direction
- 10 Prototype Scope & Milestones

The one line pitch

Animal Crossing warmth meets a living city. Players move in, pick up a job, chase a hobby, decorate a home, and build friendships with neighbors and each other, all at their own relaxed pace.

01 Project Overview

City Critters is a zero stress, socially driven life sim built for players who want a warm place to hang out with friends. There are no fail states and no timers pushing the player forward. Instead, the city offers a wide menu of things to do at any moment: fish by the pond, clock into a shift, tend a garden, redecorate an apartment, or simply wander and chat. Progression is gentle and always optional, tied to expanding your living space, growing your wardrobe, completing quests, and deepening relationships across the community.

Project Snapshot

Field	Detail
Working Title	City Critters
Engine	Godot 4 (GDScript)
Platform	PC, distributed via Steam with online multiplayer
Genre	3D casual cute multiplayer life sim
Perspective	Third person, toon styled 3D
Target Audience	Ages 13+, family friendly (E for Everyone)
Session Style	Drop in, drop out, self paced, no fail states

Core Pillars

Every feature is measured against three pillars. If a mechanic does not serve at least one of them, it does not belong in the game.

1. Hang out and have fun

A calm, welcoming environment with no pressure and no losing. The player is always free to do nothing at all, and that is a valid way to play.

2. Explore a massive, diverse world

A city roughly the scale of Los Angeles, split into distinct biomes and districts that each feel worth discovering and returning to.

3. Create friendships

Meaningful bonds with both other players and schedule driven NPCs, rewarded with lore, unlocks, and shared moments.

02 Core Gameplay Loop

Players enter the city to live out a relaxing second life alongside friends. A typical session flows naturally between low commitment activities, with currency and relationships as the quiet threads that tie everything together.

The Moment to Moment Flow

- Arrive and socialize. Spawn into a shared world, meet up with friends, and see who else is around.
- Earn. Clock into a job minigame to earn the city currency at a pace that suits the mood.
- Play. Break away for a hobby such as fishing, gardening, cooking, music, art, or sports.
- Progress. Spend earnings on furniture, outfits, apartment upgrades, or a storefront.
- Connect. Talk to and gift NPCs to build rapport, chase quests, and unlock new content.

Progression Vectors

Progression is deliberately horizontal. Rather than a single power curve, players grow along several parallel tracks and choose which to pursue.

Vector	What Grows	Long Term Goal
Living Space	Studio to apartment to house	A fully decorated dream home
Wardrobe	Outfits, accessories, species	Full self expression
Careers & Hobbies	Job levels and hobby skill	Mastery and leaderboards
Relationships	NPC rapport and player friends	Lore, unlocks, marriage
Business	Owned storefronts	A self run city enterprise

03

Player Characters & Customization

Players control 3D toon styled animal avatars built for accessible but expressive personalization. The goal is for two players to feel instantly distinct from one another while keeping the creator simple enough for a first time player.

Playable Species

Everyone begins with a friendly starter species. Additional species are earned through play, giving social effort a tangible cosmetic payoff.

Species	Availability	How It Is Unlocked
Cat	Starter	Available from character creation
Dog	Starter	Available from character creation
Avian	Unlockable	High rapport with avian NPCs
Reptile / Amphibian	Unlockable	High rapport with reptile NPCs
Equestrian	Unlockable	High rapport with equestrian NPCs
Marsupial	Unlockable	High rapport with marsupial NPCs
Cervidae (Deer)	Unlockable	High rapport with deer NPCs
Bear	Unlockable	High rapport with bear NPCs
Primate	Unlockable	High rapport with primate NPCs
Rodent / Ailuridae	Unlockable	High rapport with red panda or raccoon NPCs

Unlock Mechanic

Building high rapport with an NPC of a given species unlocks the ability to play as that species. This ties the customization economy directly into the social systems: the more the player invests in the city's residents, the more of themselves they can express.

Customization Options

Customization is layered so players can start simple and go deep later. Confirmed options for the current design are:

- Eyes and mouth shapes for personality and expression
- Distinct markings such as spots, patches, and stripes
- Ear shapes and head shapes for silhouette variety

- Base colors across the body, applied through swappable textures
- Clothing and accessories earned or bought in the city

For the initial build, color variation is delivered through swappable textures so new palettes can be added without touching the base mesh, keeping the pipeline light for the content team.

04

Activities & Hobbies

Hobbies are the heart of the calm loop. Each is a self contained, skill based minigame that rewards the player with currency, collectibles, or things to show off at home.

Fishing

Reference feel: Webfishing style casting and reeling

Players cast into the city's lake and pond, time their reel, and land a variety of fish. It is designed as the signature relaxing activity, easy to pick up and pleasant to repeat.

Rewards: Fish can be sold, cooked, displayed in a personal aquarium, or donated to the City Aquarium.

Gardening

Reference feel: Stardew Valley style crop growing

A plot based system with growth timers and varied soil states. Crops need watering, and rain automatically waters everything, rewarding players who check in across real time.

Rewards: Harvested produce feeds into cooking, decoration, and sales.

Cooking

Reference feel: Cooking Mama style active minigames

Hands on preparation minigames turn raw ingredients (including caught fish and grown produce) into finished dishes.

Rewards: Food can be sold, gifted to other players, or displayed decoratively at home.

Street Art (Tagging)

Reference feel: Creative expression with anti griefing guardrails

Players tag designated walls with their own art. To prevent griefing, tagging happens inside an instanced square boundary that other players cannot interfere with. A dedicated upgrade path and a prestige system reward committed artists.

Rewards: Cosmetic upgrades, larger canvases, and prestige recognition.

Music

Reference feel: Playable instruments with live keyboard input

Instruments respond to active keyboard play. Players can busk for tips and receive requests to perform live at venues around the city.

Rewards: Tips, performance requests, and reputation as a city musician.

Sports & Skateboarding

Reference feel: Wii Sports physics and Tony Hawk style skating

Pick up sports and a physics driven skating system give players an active outlet, tied into competitive leaderboards for those who want a challenge.

Rewards: Leaderboard placement and competitive bragging rights.

05 The Economy & Jobs

Currency is the connective tissue of the city. Players earn it through career minigames and spend it on the things that make the city feel like home. Jobs are optional and designed as fun activities in their own right, never as a grind.

Job Types

Job	Reference Feel	Core Loop
Food Service / Cafe	Papa's Pizzeria style service	Take orders, prepare, serve on time
Retail	Inventory management	Buy stock, shelve, arrange displays, run the register
Delivery / Postal	Fetch and traversal	Pick up parcels and route them across the city
Corporate Office	Satirical office tasks	Stock market, budgets, and spreadsheet puzzles

Where Currency Goes

- Furniture and interior decorations
- Player outfits and accessories
- Upgrading to better apartments or houses
- Purchasing storefronts to run personal businesses
- Paying other players for services and jobs (tentative)

Design note: player driven economy

Paying other players for services is marked tentative. It is a strong long term hook for a living city, but it needs careful balancing and anti abuse design before it enters the build.

06 Player Housing & Real Estate

Housing is grid based and heavily upgrade centric, giving every player a constant, comfortable long term goal. It is the primary canvas for self expression and the main currency sink in the game.

Progression Tiers

Tier	Space	Unlocked By
Starter	A barebones, very small studio apartment	Given to every new player
Expanded	A larger, upgraded apartment	Spending currency on expansions
Home	A standalone house in the suburbs	Continued investment
Business	Owned storefront converted from office space	Purchasing empty city offices

Grid Based Building

Furniture and decorations snap to a grid inside instanced interiors. This keeps placement readable and network friendly, and lets the content team add new furniture as simple data driven items.

Business Ownership

Empty office spaces around the city can be purchased and converted into player run storefronts, turning the housing system into an entry point for the wider player economy.

07 The World: The City

The city is roughly the size of Los Angeles, heavily sectioned into distinct biomes and districts so that travel always feels like discovery. Each hangout spot has its own identity and its own reason to visit.

Primary Hangout Spots

District	Role in the City
Storefront Plaza	The commercial hub for shopping and player run businesses
City Library	A quiet social space and a home for lore and collectibles
Nightclub	A lively evening venue with music and social energy
Arcade	Casual minigames and a hangout for friends
Aquarium	A community showcase populated by player fish donations
Public Park	Open green space for gatherings and outdoor hobbies
Suburban Neighborhoods	Player housing districts
Lake / Pond	The primary fishing hub

Districts are separated into biomes to give the world visual and tonal variety, from the bustle of the plaza to the calm of the lakeside. The scale is a long term ambition; the build grows district by district from a single polished starting area.

08

NPCs & Social Systems

The city is populated by diverse, schedule driven NPCs that make it feel genuinely alive. They are the backbone of the friendship pillar and the gateway to unlocking new species.

Schedules

NPCs follow dynamic daily paths and routines in the spirit of Stardew Valley and Palia. Residents move between home, work, and leisure across the day, so the city always feels populated and worth observing.

Relationship Building

Players build rapport by talking to NPCs and gifting them items. Rising rapport is the key that unlocks species, exclusive items, and deeper story content.

Lore & Rewards

Each NPC carries a unique backstory revealed over time. High rapport yields exclusive, NPC specific items that cannot be obtained any other way.

Events & Marriage

Special heart events punctuate growing relationships, and players can eventually marry NPCs, giving the social loop a meaningful emotional peak.

System link: NPCs power everything

Species unlocks, exclusive cosmetics, quests, and lore all route through NPC rapport. Investing in the friendship system is what keeps the calm loop rewarding over the long term.

09 Technical Direction

City Critters is built in Godot 4 with GDScript, engineered so the prototype is a clean foundation the client can expand independently. Modularity is a first class requirement, not an afterthought.

Architecture Principles

- Modular systems. Character control, jobs, hobbies, housing, and NPCs are built as self contained components with clean boundaries.
- Replicable modules. Each core system is structured so new jobs, hobbies, species, and districts can be duplicated and extended without rewrites.
- Data driven content. Furniture, cosmetics, and items are added as data rather than bespoke code, keeping content growth cheap.
- Clean project structure. A tidy folder layout and commented code so the client's team can navigate and build on the source confidently.

Multiplayer Foundation

The prototype establishes an online multiplayer foundation where players can join a shared session and see one another move through the same world in real time. This foundation is the base that all networked features are layered onto as the game grows.

Player & Animation

The avatar uses a third person 3D character controller with root motion driven idle, walk, run, and jump animations. Placeholder characters and animations sourced from Mixamo stand in until the client's bespoke art is ready, and the system is built to swap them out cleanly.

10 Prototype Scope & Milestones

The full design above describes the complete live service vision. The current engagement delivers a modular prototype that proves the core loop and serves as the foundation for everything else. This section defines exactly what is in scope.

What the Prototype Delivers

- One playable district to explore with a third person 3D character controller
- One base species (Cat or Dog) with basic color customization
- A multiplayer foundation where players join a session and see each other in one world
- One fully playable job minigame (for example Food Service) that earns currency
- One fully playable hobby (for example Fishing or Gardening)
- A small instanced apartment with grid based furniture placement and starter items to buy
- Two to three NPCs with basic schedules, dialogue, and a simple gifting system
- All systems built as modular Godot 4 components with clean structure and commented code

Everything else in this document (additional districts, species, marriage, storefronts, and leaderboards) is designed to be built on top of this foundation.

Milestone Plan

Milestone	Duration	Value
Project setup + 3D character controller	7 days	\$80
Multiplayer foundation + customization	10 days	\$120
Job minigame + currency system	10 days	\$100
Housing + NPC systems	10 days	\$120
Polish, cleanup + handoff	7 days	\$80
Total	44 days	\$500

Assumptions & Placeholders

- Placeholder 3D assets stand in for characters and the city until the client supplies final art.
- Confirmed customization scope for the build is clothing, colors, and small body parts (ears, eyes, mouth).
- Multiplayer is validated locally during development; virtual machine testing may not display GPU dependent models, which is a testing limitation only, not a game issue.

Built to grow

The prototype is intentionally architected as a launchpad. Modular systems, clean folders, and commented code mean the client's team can replicate modules and expand City Critters toward the full vision without reworking the foundation.